

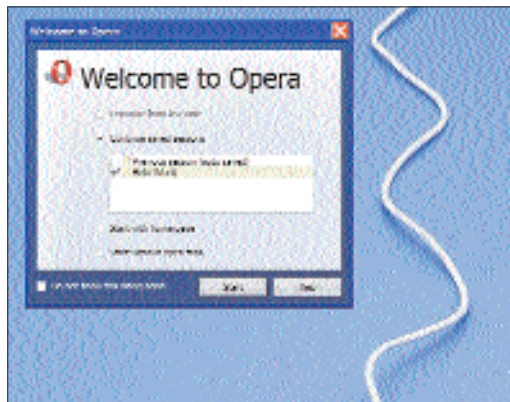
Norway-based Opera Software decided to remove the hurdles of banner ads, waived the licensing fee, and thus freed the browser. Which is where this article comes in: there is little reason for you not to be using this browser. Opera is as comprehensive a package as you'd want to take you online. Much more than just a Web browser, Opera comes with an e-mail client, a contacts manager, an IRC chat client, an RSS feed reader, a download manager, and a pop-up blocker; it offers tabbed browsing, visual themes, mouse gestures, keyboard navigation, smooth zooming of both fonts and images, a trash can that holds all the pages you've closed, a session feature that lets you resume browsing from where you left off in the event of a crash and much, much more. All in a free, 4 MB package.

The upcoming release (which you can download as a technology preview) adds BitTorrent support, widgets, a content blocker, thumbnail preview of tabs, and follows only Konqueror to pass the Acid2 Web compatibility test—which essentially tells a Web designer whether the browser is compatible with W3C standards.

So let's take a look at what this Web platform can do for you, starting with some good old-fashioned browsing.

Web Browsing 2.0

Each time you fire up Opera, you start what is called a session. You can launch a separate session by pressing [Ctrl] + [Alt] + [N]. Since Opera supports tabbed browsing, each session can have multiple tabs. Two features emerge from the concept of sessions: you can save a session and launch it with Opera, and you can resume a session in the event of a system crash. Saving a session is a great way around having to bookmark all the sites you're

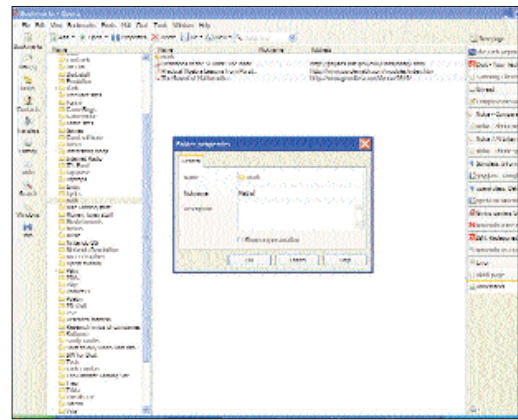


You can load a saved session when Opera loads or you can ask Opera to auto-load the session every time it starts

browsing. To do this, open up the sites in new tabs—[Ctrl] + [N] opens a new tab—then go to **File > Session > Save this session**. Note that you can choose to auto-launch your selection of sites when Opera launches. On a related note, to change the launch behaviour, go to **Tools > Preferences** and choose an option from the Startup drop-down list.

You can also launch a group of bookmarks from the address bar for similar functionality. In our example, we have a bookmark folder called Math, which contains three Web sites pertaining to mathematics. Say we want to launch the three

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You can launch a bunch of bookmarks by typing one nickname in the address bar

in Opera using a single keyword. To do this, go to **Bookmarks > Manage Bookmarks**, right-click on the Math folder, click on Properties, and then type in an appropriate nickname—we choose “maths” here, and typing in “maths” in the address bar will launch the three bookmarked Web sites.

Opera offers spatial browsing, which in essence enables traversing a Web site solely via the keyboard. For example, hitting the arrow keys while keeping [Shift] pressed will ask Opera to cycle through all the links on a page, and any form elements:

Navigate links and form elements	[Shift] + [Arrow keys]
Cycle through headers	[S] and [W]
Cycle through elements	[D] and [E]
Cycle through frames	[3] and [Shift] + [3]

Opera lets you search for text or links within a page, displaying results live as you type. Trigger a text search via the full-stop key—[.]. Similarly, you can search for any links in a Web page via the comma [,].

One of the most useful features of Opera is its integration with the Answers.com online service. No longer do you have to wonder about the meaning of a word—whether it's pertaining to simple usage or something technical, the service tells you everything you'd need to know, and even suggests correct pronunciation via audio. To trigger this, just double-click on the word in question and click on Dictionary. Opera will take you to the relevant Answers.com page, which collates information from a variety of sources including dictionaries, thesaurus, encyclopaedias, translations, and real-time data such as weather reports, currency converters and stock tickers. The selection need not be limited to just a word—phrases, too, can be selected in this manner. A very useful feature, especially if you are a researcher or student.

While using this feature, you might have noticed the Translate option on the right-click menu. As the name suggests, the feature uses different engines to translate a block of text in a variety of language pairs including French to English, German to English, Italian to English and Japanese to English. It beats having to separately visit Babelfish or the Google online translator.

Another nifty feature for the data collectors